

HOW TO OVERCOME TEMPTATION

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: **Matthew 4:1-11** (NKJV) *“Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. ² And when He had fasted forty days and forty nights, afterward He was hungry. ³ Now when the tempter came to Him, he said, ‘If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.’ ⁴ But He answered and said, ‘It is written, ‘Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God.’” ⁵ Then the devil took Him up into the holy city, set Him on the pinnacle of the temple, ⁶ and said to Him, “If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot*

against a stone.””⁷ Jesus said to him, “It is written again, ‘You shall not tempt the LORD your God.’”⁸ Again, the devil took Him up on an exceedingly high mountain, and showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory.⁹ And he said to Him, “All these things I will give You if You will fall down and worship me.”¹⁰ Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan! For it is written, ‘You shall worship the LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’”¹¹ Then the devil left Him, and behold, angels came and ministered to Him.”

INTRO: The story of the temptation of Jesus seems to have a strange setting indeed. A baptismal service was being conducted in the Jordan River and John the Baptist was the name of the minister performing the ordinance of water baptism. John was not cut from the cloth of normal priestly protocol quite the contrary is true: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- His message was a departure from the norm - His was a message of repentance.
- His attire was anything but fashionable - A camels skin suit held in place by a leather girdle.
- His diet was shocking - His favorite meal was grasshoppers and wild honey.

John was the Grizzly Adams of the religious right. He was a terrible fashion disaster whose diet was never copied.

A phenomenon unlike anything the current religious leaders had ever saw was beginning to occur, though his habits were terribly unorthodox and his message anything but consoling, great multitudes followed the ministry of John The Baptist. The impact of his ministry would be such, that the effects of it would be felt for more than two thousand years.

Immediately following the baptism of one of the candidates John looked up to see a young man approaching from the distant horizon. As the man drew nearer John recognized the familiar stride of his cousin, Jesus Christ. In his attempt to exchange pleasantries with Jesus, John utters words that would become an historic anomaly and a prophetic benchmark; "***Behold the lamb of God which taketh away the sins of the world.***" Everyone in the crowd caught and held their breath; exchanged glances of wonder; and were apparently shocked at the bold statement of this wilderness preacher. John was certainly not one who made a habit of mincing words or beating around the bush but this was an uncharacteristically bold statement, even for John.

Every Jewish person gathered in this small group of converts was very well rehearsed with regard to the work of the sacrificial lamb on the Day of Atonement. In his

declaration of his Cousin Jesus' arrival, John not only declared Jesus to be a lamb but ***"THE Lamb of God"*** that would ***"TAKE AWAY the sins of the world."*** John was declaring that Jesus would attain a threshold of achievement that no other lamb for centuries past had been able to attain, though they had given their very lives. The work of the lamb that John was speaking of would be to forgive sin - not just roll them ahead a year at a time. For all practical purposes John declared Jesus to be the Messiah!

Following such an announcement, you would expect Jesus to:

- Pull together a ministry team...
- Write a book...
- Develop a magazine...
- Establish a television ministry
- Build a base of support...

In short, do the things that are generally expected and necessary to begin a ministry

that is capable of touching the entire earth. True to His unconventional model of ministry Jesus does nothing of the sort; In fact, He seems to downplay the announcement by requesting to be baptized by this rugged wilderness preacher.

Upon His baptism, a wonderful phenomenon occurred involving a dove, defying its nature to make physical contact with a human being, and a voice booming from the sky saying *"This is my beloved son in whom I am well pleased."*

This is the stuff wildly popular movies and superstars are made of. The really shocking feature of this entire story is what happens next: Jesus is *"Led of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil."*

The expectation of the casual reader is for Jesus to: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Maximize the moment...
- Strike while the iron was hot...
- Capitalize on the occasion...

But He does nothing of the sort; He goes into seclusion! What a waste of momentum! Can you imagine such a thing? And He is doing all of this at the instruction of the Spirit.

The picture becomes extremely vague over the next forty days but we do know Jesus passed the time fasting and praying and in fellowship with the father. Following this forty-day rendezvous with God Jesus emerges from His sabbatical only to be met by a direct assault from Satan himself. The events that follow are commonly referred to as the "*Temptation of Jesus*".

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TEMPTATION AND TESTING

The "*Temptation of Jesus*" is not what most people have believed it to be. There is certainly more to it than would be immediately apparent to the casual reader or somewhat distracted observer. This temptation could probably be better described as the "*Testing of Jesus*".

A more in-depth look at these two words reveals a Scriptural truth that has been almost totally ignored. **Temptation is always self-inflicted just as testing is allowed by our Heavenly Father for the purpose of: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Strengthening us...
- Building our faith...
- Preparing us for greatness...
- Developing character that can stand the onslaught of success and failure...

On the other hand, temptation as we know it, the enticement to do evil: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Does not build our faith...
- Does not better prepare us for success or failure...
- Is destructive to our character...

The motive of this kind of temptation is: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To entice us to do evil...
- Terminate our influence...
- Separate us from close fellowship with God...
- Destroy the destiny God has called us to...

The testing of Jesus did not have anything to do with a moral lapse but had everything to do with the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life. 1 John 2:15-17 (NKJV) ***"Do not love the world or the***

things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him.16 For all that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not of the Father but is of the world.17 And the world is passing away, and the lust of it; but he who does the will of God abides forever." The lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life, has to do with **the three-part composition of man: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Body
- Soul
- Spirit

The testing of Jesus consisted of the following: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **The lust of the flesh** - He had not received nourishment for his body for forty days, and the first thing the enemy attempted to do was entice Him to use His supernatural ability to satisfy the

flesh side of His nature. ***“If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.”*** Was He hungry? He was starving! I have heard individuals who were attempting to sound super spiritual say they fasted for several days and never experienced hunger! I have fasted extensively for many years, fasting at one point thirty days, drinking only water (losing 47 pounds in 30 days), and I can tell you that I craved food I otherwise didn't even like. People who fast and do not get hungry are either far more spiritual than Jesus, they are lying, or they are sneaking around and eating in private. Jesus was hungry and this was a test of the flesh. After forty days of fasting Jesus' flesh was no doubt screaming for nourishment. The enemy tested Jesus' commitment by attempting to get Him to use his supernatural abilities to satisfy the flesh.

- **The Lust of the eyes** - Satan tried to entice Jesus to cast himself down from the pinnacle of the temple, thus falling into a trap of using His divine connections and heightened spiritual awareness to do something that would defy natural and divine law. ***“If You are the Son of God, throw Yourself down. For it is written: ‘He shall give His angels charge over you,’ and, ‘In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot against a stone.’”*** In so doing He would have been guilty of using His powers to appeal to the senses. Our Souls consist of our mind, will, and emotions. Unless we properly control our mind, will, and emotions through the power of the Holy Spirit we tend to become more sensual than spiritual. When we allow the sensual to prevail over the spiritual, we are by an act of our own will stepping outside the protection and provision of God. When we step

outside the protection and provision of God we become drawn away of our own lust, caving in to temptation. This is a test of the sensual side of Jesus. The enemy was attempting to entice Him into the spectacular at a time of super spirituality. Jesus would have no part of it because He knew that a propensity to the sensual never satisfies the appetite of the eye. Jesus understood that if He jumped from the pinnacle of the Temple and Angels carried Him safely to the earth the sensual rush would never satisfy, but leave Him lusting for more. All attempts to satisfy the soul leave the individual lusting for more.

- **The pride of life** - Satan continues the test by attempting to appeal to the spiritual side of Jesus by leading Him to a high mountain and telling Him if He would bow down and worship, he would give Him all He could see. ***“Then Jesus said to him, “Away with you, Satan!”***

For it is written, ‘You shall worship the LORD your God, and Him only you shall serve.’” The spiritual side of every person is destined to rule as a king and priest. Because we are destined to rule as kings and priests every believer has a natural bent to worship and reign. This can get us into trouble if we worship the wrong things and try to reign over territory we are not called to. Because we have a predisposition for worshipping and reigning many of the tests that come our way will be spiritual in nature. The enemy consistently attempts to keep us from becoming all we can be in the spiritual realm and then uses our lack of perceived progress as a catalyst to convince us to give up on our destiny. Jesus had a leg up on the tempter because he was fully aware that what he was offering was not his to give. This was an illusion as are all the

enemy's claims of entitlement or bestowment.

THE VULNERABILITY OF TEMPTATION

James 1:12-15 (NKJV) *"Blessed is the man who endures temptation; for when he has been approved, he will receive the crown of life which the Lord has promised to those who love Him.13 Let no one say when he is tempted, "I am tempted by God"; for God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He Himself tempt anyone.14 But each one is tempted when he is drawn away by his own desires and enticed.15 Then, when desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, brings forth death."*

James 1:12-15 (LB) *"Happy is the man who doesn't give in and do wrong when he is tempted, for afterwards he will get as his reward the crown of life that God has promised those who love him. 13 And remember, when someone wants to do*

wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God."

There are three basic temptations or tests that we all face: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Things God allows** - This testing has its limits and our spiritual growth and character have been pre-tested and deemed sufficient for the test. I see no record in Scripture of anyone failing a test that was pre-approved by God. (Job) 1 Corinthians 10:13 (NKJV) *"No temptation has overtaken you except such as is common to man; but God is faithful, who will not allow you to be tempted beyond what you are able, but with the temptation will also make the*

way of escape, that you may be able to bear it."

- **Things Satan designs** - God will never sanction a test that allows for a moral failure. The enemy cannot force you to sin; the devil did not make you do it! He can do no more than make a brief presentation of the temptation. (King David)
- **Self-inflicted temptation** - By our own volition and imagination we take the bait of Satan and imagine our way into a situation that we are powerless to win (Samson). Son of Manoah - Angel announced his birth - He was to be a Nazarite - He was to be a deliverer for Israel - The angel of the Lord ascended in the flame from a meat offering - The Spirit of the Lord moved upon him from time to time - Judges 14:1(NKJV) "***Now Samson went down to Timnath, and saw a woman in Timnath of the daughters of the Philistines.***" He killed

30 men to get garments to give to the men of Timnath – He caught 300 foxes, set their tails on fire, and burned the Philistines corn crop up – He slew a host of Philistines hip and thigh - With the jaw bone of an ass he slew 1,000 Philistines - After this slaughter Samson was famished from thirst and God hollowed out a place in the jawbone from which water gushed forth, quenching his thirst - He frequented a prostitute in Gaza - He carried away the gates of the city of Gaza – In Judges 16:4 he meets Delilah - Breaks green vines that had never been dried - Breaks new ropes - Carries away a beam fastened to his head with a pin - He tells all - Delilah sold him out - He lost his power with God – He was blinded and made a circus attraction - He was made to grind at the enemies wheel – Upon his request God restored his unusual strength.

Temptation, as we know it, has to do with an enticement to do that which is in direct moral conflict with Biblical standards and practices. (Lying - stealing - cheating - etc.)

According to the Word, God cannot be tempted by these things and will not authorize such an attack against us! James 1:13-15 (LB) *"And remember, when someone wants to do wrong it is never God who is tempting him, for God never wants to do wrong and never tempts anyone else to do it. 14 Temptation is the pull of man's own evil thoughts and wishes. 15 These evil thoughts lead to evil actions and afterwards to the death penalty from God."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

I think we could safely say that any attack against us that has attached to it an enticement to do that which is not morally convenient, is from Satan himself. If the attack carries these illegal components, it is

a covert attack and must be dealt with as such. In fighting against such an attack we should use all the weapons at our disposal. Throw the book (the Bible) at the devil! This kind of attack is normally won or lost at the point of impact.

As we look into this verse the one thing that becomes very apparent; temptation is often self-inflicted testing is not! ***"Every man is tempted WHEN he is drawn away of his own lust and enticed."***

The fact that many of us struggle so unsuccessfully is proof that we are either acting on the thoughts the enemy has placed in our mind or we are suffering a self-inflicted temptation.

Almost unknowingly many Christians willingly place themselves in vulnerable positions. Others fail to implement a *"Search and destroy"* mentality during initial impact.

Either way we become vulnerable to the enemy who is absolutely merciless when he discovers the helplessness of his victim.

THE PROTECTION OF TESTING

You are probably thinking that Jesus faced the same temptations we do yet He did not sin. This is true; the Bible states it very vigorously. [Hebrews 4:15](#) (NKJV) *"For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin."* Hebrews 4:15 (LB) *"This High Priest of ours understands our weaknesses since he had the same temptations we do, though he never once gave way to them and sinned."*

So [what kind of temptation did Jesus face?](#)
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- [He was restricted by the limitations of the flesh](#) - He became hungry - Matthew

4 (Turn these stones into bread), this was the first way the enemy tested Him.

- He became physically exhausted - Several times in Scripture He removed Himself from the crowd for some rest and relaxation.
- He became lonely - *"Foxes have holes, birds have nests, but the son of man does not have a place to lay His head."*
- He suffered rejection - The betrayal of Judas. The night prior to the crucifixion Jesus was agonizing in prayer and the disciples could not stay awake with Him for one hour - We can almost hear the rejection in Jesus' voice as He say's *"Sleep on now."*
- He endured conflict within His family – Mary and Joseph looking for Him after He had been gone three days.
- He was tempted to get angry and lose His temper - Dealing with the mercenaries in the Temple.

- He suffered physical pain - His crucifixion.

Though Jesus was tested in many ways, there is not one shred of evidence in the Bible that He was tempted to do anything in conflict with Biblical standards or practices!

- He was never tempted to relegate God to anything but first place in His life!
- He was never tempted to commit idolatry!
- He was never tempted to serve any God but Jehovah!
- He was never tempted to curse!
- He was never tempted to dishonor the Lord's Day!
- He was never tempted to dishonor His parents!
- He was never tempted to take an innocent life!
- He never lusted after another man's wife!

- He was never tempted to take anything that did not belong to Him!
- He was never tempted to covet another man's possessions!

Did the idea of doing any of these things ever enter into the mind of Jesus? I'm sure it did, but He knew the power of casting imaginations down upon impact.

This is where our battle with the devil is won or lost. If we allow the mental process to go beyond an initial thought we have stepped outside the protection God has so graciously provided. When we allow ourselves to step outside His protection and provision we are no match for the devil.

Just as Jesus overcame the temptation to do wrong, if we will cast every thought of immorality and unscriptural practice down upon impact we will never be tempted to do these things either!

In the Old Testament Job experienced a test - not a temptation - a test! The test Job

faced was actually brought on by the fact God was bragging about Job's integrity and spiritual maturity. God said to the devil ***"Have you noticed my servant Job? He is the finest man in all the earth — a good man who fears God and will have nothing to do with evil."*** Job 1:8 (LB) Considering the overall story of the testing of Job it is obvious; all that came against him had to first of all meet the approval of God. That sounds strange indeed but it is nonetheless true! Job 23:10 (NKJV) ***"But He knows the way that I take; When He has tested me, I shall come forth as gold."***

The tests we face come as no surprise to God. They sometimes hit us broadside but they never catch God off guard.

Every test we face must meet the approval of God in advance. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

God looks at the test and then looks at where we are and what we are capable of enduring in the physical, emotional, and spiritual

realm. In this process He considers our faith and endurance and would never allow the enemy to bring anything against us that we are incapable of handling. ***"No testing has overtaken you that is not common to everyone. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tested beyond your strength, but with the testing he will also provide the way out so that you may be able to endure it."***

There is no way of getting around it or avoiding it, the fact is God allowed this test to come into Job's life - He could have prevented it but He did not choose to do so. Why do you suppose God chose such a course of action?

He was strengthening Job; building his faith; preparing him for a time of success and greatness that was beyond his wildest imagination. Job was about to be given twice as much as he had before the test; twice as many children; twice as many cattle and oxen; twice as many resources; twice as much life! Job was seventy years old at the

onset of the test, and he lived to be two hundred and ten years old!

When we stop to think about it, Job was enduring a test that he could not fail because God had already examined the test and evaluated Job's integrity and spiritual maturity. The enemy initiated a battle that he was predisposed to lose from the beginning.

Testing has to do with living in right relationship with God and others regardless of the pressure to do otherwise. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

Testing also has to do with standing on the promises of God despite the temptation to do otherwise. To the person who is tested by God the highest form of reality is what the Word of God has to say on the subject.

In the testing of Jesus He took three scriptures out of the Old Testament book of

Deuteronomy and whipped the devil all over the desert. I am convinced that God looked at the test and then at His son Jesus and said something like this to an angel; *"This should be good; Satan wants to test Jesus by offering Him food, sensationalism, and power! What a dumb devil, doesn't he know who Jesus is and where He has been?"* By the way, we are also sons of God and have been given the same rights, privileges and power as Jesus had when He was upon the earth.

The bottom line here is temptation has everything to do with our own lusts and appetites, testing has to do with our personal development and spiritual maturity.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) When we are working our way through a test rather than a temptation the sounds, sights, and smell of victory are never beyond our reach!

PRACTICAL APPLICATION

The key to our success in any test we face is as follows: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Live within the hedge of protection God has cast for us. The hedge consists of the Blood of Jesus and the Word of God. As long as we live our lives within those perimeters we have nothing to fear from the enemy. He can't win and we can't lose!
- Never allow the devil to entice us to step outside the Bloodline. We must never allow him to convince us that even though the Word of God speaks out against a certain behavior God will make an exception for us.

HOW TO OVERCOME REJECTION

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Genesis 37:3-4 (NKJV) *“Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he made him a tunic of many colors. ⁴But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him.”* Genesis 45:3-8 (NKJV) *“Then Joseph said to his brothers, “I am Joseph; does my father still live?” But his brothers could not answer him, for they were dismayed in his presence. ⁴And Joseph said to his brothers, “Please come near to me.” So they came near. Then he said: “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. ⁵“But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ⁶“For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷“And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance.”*

INTRO: We live in a world of rejection; individuals are being rejected in the following ways: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Spouses are rejected by their companions...
- Children feel the rejection of divorce...
- Business people are rejected by partners and clients...
- Friends are rejected and betrayed despite life-long relationships...
- Corporations terminate employees who have given their best years to build the company...
- Citizens are rejected by politicians who have their own best interest at heart, rather than the good of the people...

The list could continue on into infinity. The world has a way of bruising and battering its inhabitants. Sin is the primary cause of all rejection. Selfishness is the root of all sin. Though the world beats up its populace, Jesus stands ready to heal all broken hearts. Luke 4:18-

19 (NKJV) ***"The Spirit of the LORD is upon Me, Because He has anointed Me To preach the gospel to the poor; He has sent Me to heal the brokenhearted, To proclaim liberty to the captives And recovery of sight to the blind, To set at liberty those who are oppressed; ¹⁹ To proclaim the acceptable year of the LORD."***

In order to get a handle on a plan for recovering from rejection, I want us to look at a Biblical character who suffered rejection at every level. Over the next couple of weeks we are going to do an in depth study of the life of Joseph. I love the story of the life of Joseph because it is a perfect example of a life marked and marred by adversity, yet, despite the problematic path, the grace of God is shown through a life of integrity. Though Joseph was born with a silver spoon in his mouth, the real Joseph is placed on display when crisis after crisis attempts to keep him from all God intended him to be.

Look at a snapshot of Joseph's life:

- Joseph was the son of Jacob and Rachel...
- At the age of seventeen he is tending the flock of Jacob, his Father...
- Joseph was the favorite child of his father because he was the child of his old age...
- Because of parental partiality, he was hated by his brothers... (Coat of Many Colors)
- He began to dream dreams of exaltation, such as the dream of binding sheaves and the sheaves of his brothers bowing down to him; the sun, the moon, and eleven stars making obeisance to him...
- Because of his dreams, his brother's dislike for him turned to hatred...
- Joseph's brothers conspire to kill him, but Reuben says, ***"Let's put him in a pit and leave him there,"*** thinking he would come later and deliver Joseph unto his father...
- His brothers took his Coat of many Colors and dipped it in blood, deliver it unto Jacob, his father, and allowed him to believe a wild beast killed Joseph... (His brothers actually sold him to the Midianites)
- The Midianite Merchantmen sold him to the Ishmeelites for 20 pieces of silver...
- The Ishmeelites sold Joseph to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh...
- Potiphar recognizes the Lord is with Joseph, because everything Joseph touches becomes a success...

- Potiphar makes Joseph the Business Manager of his entire fortune...
- God prospers Joseph as the business manager of Potiphar, as a result, his master realizes some very hefty profits...
- The wife of Potiphar tries unsuccessfully to seduce Joseph... Notice the words of Joseph when faced with such a tantalizing temptation, ***“I refuse to commit this sin against my God.”***
- When the wife of Potiphar sees that Joseph is a young man of integrity and will not commit adultery with her, she lies to Potiphar and Joseph is put in prison...
- Joseph is made overseer of all the prisoners...
- While Joseph is in prison, Pharaoh’s butler and baker become inmates...
- The butler and baker both dream dreams and Joseph interprets them upon the condition that when the butler is restored, he will tell the king of Joseph’s injustice...
- Just as Joseph predicts, the butler is restored to the King’s favor and the baker is hanged...
- Two years pass before the butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...
- Pharaoh dreams a dream that no one could interpret. This dream was of seven fat cattle coming up out of the river and then seven poor cattle coming up out of the river. The seven poor cattle ate up the seven fat cattle. Then he dreamed again and seven fat ears of corn sprang up on one stalk and seven thin ears of corn on another stalk blasted by the east wind. The seven thin ears ate up the seven fat ears. Pharaoh had a nightmare...
- Pharaoh’s butler says, ***“I know someone who can interpret this dream.”*** The butler makes good on his promise to Joseph...
- Joseph interprets Pharaoh’s dream of seven years of plenty and seven years of famine...
- Joseph is made second-in-command in Egypt...

Remember, about fourteen years have transpired since Joseph was sold into Egypt. The path he was called upon to travel to the palace was not Easy Street! Everyone who is great for God has traveled a path which is strewn with havoc, rejection and difficulty. [Look at the Heroes of the faith:](#)
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- [Abel’s faith cost him his life, but his blood spoke from the ground...](#)

- Enoch's faith caused him to walk with God... Anyone who walks with God will be hated by the world!
- Noah's faith caused him to build an Ark in a climate where it had never rained before...
- Abraham's faith caused him to leave his homeland and offer his son Isaac on the altar of sacrifice...
- Moses' faith caused him to defy Pharaoh and lead the Children of Israel to the Promised Land...
- Paul's faith landed him in jail...

Listen to this; [Hebrews 11:32-40](#) (NKJV) ***"And what more shall I say? For the time would fail me to tell of Gideon and Barak and Samson and Jephthah, also of David and Samuel and the prophets: ³³who through faith subdued kingdoms, worked righteousness, obtained promises, stopped the mouths of lions, ³⁴quenched the violence of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, out of weakness were made strong, became valiant in battle, turned to flight the armies of the aliens. ³⁵Women received their dead raised to life again. And others were tortured, not accepting deliverance, that they might obtain a better resurrection. ³⁶Still others had trial of mockings and scourgings, yes, and of chains and imprisonment. ³⁷They were stoned, they were sawn in two, were tempted, were slain with the sword. They wandered about in sheepskins and goatskins, being destitute, afflicted, tormented—³⁸of whom the world was not worthy. They wandered in deserts and mountains, in dens and caves of the earth. ³⁹And all these, having obtained a good testimony through faith, did not receive the promise, ⁴⁰God having provided something better for us, that they should not be made perfect apart from us."***

(END OF SERMON #1)

I. FORGIVENESS IS ESSENTIAL TO OVERCOMING REJECTION...

In Bible days, people named their children for something of significance in their life. When Joseph's first child was born he named him Manasseh. [Manasseh](#) means ***"causing to forget or forgetfulness."*** Notice vs. 51 ***"And Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: For God, said he hath made me forget all my toil, and all my father's house."***

What is Joseph saying here?

- Is he saying God has removed his mother, father and eleven brothers from his memory? No!
- Is he saying God has erased the maltreatment by his siblings from his memory? No!
- Is he saying God has stricken the rejection by his brothers from his memory? No!

He is simply saying that God has taken the pain out of a past experience for Him. If anyone has ever had a reason to be bitter and have a critical attitude, surely Joseph did.

How could a guy who had been through what Joseph had endured ever be able to get past the pain? The path to peace in Joseph's life is really pretty simple. When his first son was born, he named him Manasseh meaning, ***"The Lord hath made me to forget."*** While Joseph could not forget his father, mother and eleven brothers, what he could do was to forgive them, and that he did!

Have you ever been wronged? Been rejected? Treated badly? Been double crossed? Cheated out of something? These things can bring with them a boat load of pain; how we react to these things will define who we are! If we forgive, we can move on with our life and become who God intended us to be. If we withhold forgiveness, we immediately become stunted in our growth pattern and slowly but surely become critical if not downright bitter!

Many have critical spirits, who call themselves Christians. Why are they critical? Because they have never come to a place of letting God take the pain out of a past experience. Past experiences are why some people don't serve God today. If we allow past experiences to stand between us and serving God, we will lose out with God and our lives will be less than they were intended to be.

Most people fail to forgive, hoping to inflict pain on the un-forgiven individual when in reality [**the person who is withholding forgiveness places themselves in a prison for a life term or until forgiveness can be dispensed.**](#)

I don't know what you have been going through but if Joseph could endure all this, and forget the past, surely you and I can forget the past and serve God victoriously!

Keys to victory: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Allow God to take the pain out of a past experience... Paul, who had everything happen to him except his life being taken from him says in [Philippians 3:13-14](#) (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*** How in the world is it possible to allow God to take the pain out of a past experience for us? First of all we must forgive! While teaching His disciples how to pray, Jesus makes this statement, [Matthew 6:12](#) (NKJV) ***“And forgive us our debts, As we forgive our debtors.”*** If that is not enough, following “The Lord’s Prayer” He says to His disciples, almost as an afterthought, [Matthew 6:14-15](#) (NKJV) ***“For if you forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. ¹⁵“But if you do not forgive men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”*** How is this kind of forgiveness possible? The Bible tells us that God has ***“Taken our sins and cast them as far as the East is from the West never to be remembered against us again.”*** Think of what Christ did for us upon the cross of Calvary. Now think of all the times we have sinned against Him. As soon as we asked to be forgiven, He forgave us and forgot it, pure and simple! If He has done all of this for us, then we cannot withhold forgiveness from our brethren. (Ex. Parable of man who owed his master much, the debt was forgiven, and then he turned around and did not forgive a little debt owed to him.) Many people are just that way. Not only must we forgive, but if we think your brother or sister has a problem with us, we are responsible to go to that person and straighten things out. [Matthew 5:23-24](#) (NKJV) ***“Therefore if you bring your gift to the altar, and there remember that your brother has something against you, ²⁴“leave your gift there before the altar, and go your way. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.”*** A lack of forgiveness is the very reason many Christians never mature, they have never learned to forgive. A good exercise for forgiveness is to write a letter of forgiveness... Make a phone call of forgiveness...
- Live in the present and the future and minimize the failures of the past... [Philippians 3:13-14](#) (NKJV) ***“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of***

God in Christ Jesus.” Un-forgiveness requires a lot of energy and attention. If we channel this energy and attention toward what is happening today and tomorrow we will not have what it takes to keep holding to the past!

- Do good deeds to those who have wronged us... Matthew 5:43-45 (NKJV) ***“You have heard that it was said, ‘You shall love your neighbor and hate your enemy.’ ⁴⁴“But I say to you, love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you, ⁴⁵“that you may be sons of your Father in heaven; for He makes His sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust.”*** That’s a tall order, so how do we do this? Paul told the Philippian Christians, **Philippians 4:8** (NKJV) ***“Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things.”*** When we begin to allow God’s Word to do its work in us we do not have to do God’s work for Him, He will manifest His miracles through us! **We must allow our minds to be ridded of past failures, defeats, and wrongs, by dwelling on good things, forgetting the past, and dwelling on the future!**

We see a perfect example of these things being pressed into service in the life of Joseph. Joseph’s 10 brothers came to buy corn in Egypt at the command of their father Jacob. Joseph had the authority and the motive to kill every one of them but notice what he did. He gives them their corn, and puts their money back in their sacks. He keeps Simeon so that they will bring Benjamin back with them.

As a last resort, Jacob consents to let Benjamin come with them. Joseph makes a feast for them, gives them corn and supplies, and once again puts their money back in their sacks, only this time he puts his silver cup in Benjamin’s sack and lets them go. When they are gone, he sends his servants after them and his servants find the cup in Benjamin’s sack. Joseph’s brothers plead with him, not knowing with whom they were pleading then he reveals who he is. His brothers are afraid for their lives.

Listen to the words of Joseph when his brothers realize who they are dealing with. **Genesis 45:4-8** (NKJV) ***“And Joseph said to his brothers, “Please***

come near to me.” So they came near. Then he said: “I am Joseph your brother, whom you sold into Egypt. ⁵“But now, do not therefore be grieved or angry with yourselves because you sold me here; for God sent me before you to preserve life. ⁶“For these two years the famine has been in the land, and there are still five years in which there will be neither plowing nor harvesting. ⁷“And God sent me before you to preserve a posterity for you in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. ⁸“So now it was not you who sent me here, but God; and He has made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.”

The reason Joseph could deal with his brothers so gently when they came to buy corn in Egypt is because he forgave them long before they arrived!

Why? Because “*Manasseh, the Lord hath made me to forget!*” He named his son Manasseh so that each time he spoke his son’s name, he was reminded to keep forgiving his brothers. As Joseph forgave his brothers he was releasing his own family from the shackles of the curse of unforgiveness!

This very same thing can happen to you! I don’t know about you, but I believe there were probably days when the past would begin to bother him and all he had to do was to look at Manasseh and that was enough to cause him to forget the past.

II. FRUITFULNESS; THE RESULT OF FORGIVENESS...

Joseph named his second son Ephraim. Genesis 41:52 “*And the name of the second he called Ephraim: ‘For God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.’*” The name Ephraim means “*Double Fruit.*”

Remember, Joseph named his first son Manasseh because God had taken the pain out of a past experience for him. Joseph’s ability to forgive is absolutely unquestioned. Now his second son comes along and he chooses an equally important and significant name by naming him Ephraim.

There are three things which I want us to focus on: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- God caused Joseph to be fruitful...
- God caused Joseph to be fruitful in the land of his affliction...
- Joseph never lost sight of the fact that Egypt was not his home...

1) Why did God cause Joseph to be fruitful? Because he was a man of integrity and he demonstrated an ability not to allow his past to dictate the present and the future.

Far too many times **we allow our past to determine where we are today and where we are going in all of our tomorrows.** Be assured, if we cannot get past a prior failure or injury we cannot succeed today or tomorrow.

Joseph makes a declaration which flies in the face of everything we know; ***“God has caused me to be fruitful....”*** Joseph should have been a bitter failure rotting in a jail cell but he informs us that God has allowed fruitfulness in his life despite past failures and setbacks.

This is great for Joseph but how can I bring this about in my life? Live a life of integrity and forgive everyone who commits an offense against us! **The level of our integrity and ability to forgive is directly tied to the level of the success we can achieve in our lives! Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV)**

“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”

2) Joseph does not stop with the words ***“God has caused me to be fruitful...”*** If he had stopped there this would still be an amazing story on how to succeed when we have been rejected. Listen to the entire statement, ***“God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”***

Anyone can be successful when everything is going right but it takes something special to succeed when all things are against you.

Everything was against Joseph: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He was hated by his brothers...
- He was sold as an Egyptian slave...
- He was falsely accused of sexual assault...
- He was falsely imprisoned in a foreign land...
- He was estranged from everyone who could help him...

In spite of all of this he became the Prime Minister of Egypt, with all the benefits of such an office. He was an extremely powerful and wealthy man.

I can only imagine what the wife of Potiphar must have thought when she discovered Joseph was now the Prime Minister. I can only imagine what Joseph's brothers must have thought when they discovered the little brat they sold into Egyptian slavery is now the Prime Minister!

Most of us would have dealt with the wicked witch of the east at the first opportunity possible. We would have chastised or killed the people who sent us to Egypt, but Joseph never even considers such a thing, which is precisely why God could place him in such a position of authority and bless him with unbelievable wealth.

God will only give us what he can trust us with!

3) Joseph never lost sight of the fact that Egypt was not home for him; ***“God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”***

Joseph lived in the land of affliction but he walked uprightly before God. Because he walked uprightly before God, **God blessed Joseph in many ways:**
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He was blessed with Divine protection...
- He was blessed with Divine direction...
- He was blessed with positions of influence...
- He was blessed with a family who honored God...
- He was blessed in his finances...

Ephraim means *“Double Fruit.”* Every time the name Ephraim was formed on the lips of Joseph, this man of God was reminded that his success was not his own but success which had been given to him by the God he served.

Far too many of us get our sights set on what this world can offer. **Earth is not home for the Christian; at its very best it is the land of our affliction! 2 Peter 2:11-12 (CEV) “Dear friends, you are foreigners and strangers on this earth. So I beg you not to surrender to those desires that fight against you.¹² Always let others see you behaving properly, even though they may still accuse you of doing wrong. Then on the day of judgment, they will honor God by telling the good things they saw you do.” 1 Peter 1:17-19**

(CEV) “...you must honor God while you live as strangers here on earth.
¹⁸ You were rescued from the useless way of life that you learned from your ancestors. But you know that you were not rescued by such things as silver or gold that don’t last forever. ¹⁹ You were rescued by the precious blood of Christ, that spotless and innocent lamb.”

While Joseph was able to achieve unbelievable success in the land of his affliction he never allowed himself to take his focus off of the fact that he was an Israelite and Jehovah had a better plan than Egypt for him and his descendants. [Genesis 50:20-25](#) (NKJV) “So Joseph dwelt in Egypt, he and his father’s household. And Joseph lived one hundred and ten years.
²³ Joseph saw Ephraim’s children to the third generation. The children of Machir, the son of Manasseh, were also brought up on Joseph’s knees.
²⁴ And Joseph said to his brethren, “I am dying; but God will surely visit you, and bring you out of this land to the land of which He swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.” ²⁵ Then Joseph took an oath from the children of Israel, saying, “God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here.” ²⁶ So Joseph died, being one hundred and ten years old; and they embalmed him, and he was put in a coffin in Egypt.”

No matter how much wealth, notoriety, or success we achieve here, [we must keep our eyes on the fact that this earth is not home for us!](#) [1 Thessalonians 4:13-17](#) (NKJV) “But I do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning those who have fallen asleep, lest you sorrow as others who have no hope. ¹⁴ For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so God will bring with Him those who sleep in Jesus. ¹⁵ For this we say to you by the word of the Lord, that we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord will by no means precede those who are asleep. ¹⁶ For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. ¹⁷ Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord. ¹⁸ Therefore comfort one another with these words.”

[1 Corinthians 15:51-57](#) (NKJV) “Behold, I tell you a mystery: We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed— ⁵² in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed. ⁵³ For this corruptible must put on incorruption, and this mortal must put on immortality. ⁵⁴ So

when this corruptible has put on incorruption, and this mortal has put on immortality, then shall be brought to pass the saying that is written: “Death is swallowed up in victory.”⁵⁵ “O Death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?”⁵⁶ The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law.⁵⁷ But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.⁵⁸ Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain in the Lord.”

HOW TO OVERCOME A TRAGEDY

Nehemiah 1:1-2 :8 Nehemiah 1:1-8

I am Nehemiah son of Hacaliah, and in this book I tell what I have done.

1 During the month of Chislev in the twentieth year that Artaxerxes ruled Persia, I was in his fortress city of Susa, 2 when my brother Hanani came with some men from Judah. So I asked them about the Jews who had escaped from being captives in Babylonia. I also asked them about the city of Jerusalem.

3 They told me, “Those captives who have come back are having all kinds of troubles. They are terribly disgraced, Jerusalem’s walls are broken down, and its gates have been burned.”

4 When I heard this, I sat down and cried. Then for several days, I mourned; I went without eating to show my sorrow, and I prayed:

5 LORD God of heaven, you are great and fearsome. And you faithfully keep your promises to everyone who loves you and obeys your commands. 6 I am your servant, so please have mercy on me and answer the prayer that I make day and night for these people of Israel who serve you. I, my family, and the rest of your people have sinned 7 by choosing to disobey you and the laws and teachings you gave to your servant Moses.

8 Please remember the promise you made to Moses. You told him that if we were unfaithful, you would scatter us among foreign nations.¹

Intro: When tragedy strikes, some react by getting bitter, blaming God, withdrawing, and never working through a constructive reaction. Nehemiah shows us how to react positively and constructively to tragedy. His tragedy was that his homeland had been devastated, the wall of Jerusalem had been broken down. He was far away from home, and the news hit him hard. How he reacted made all the difference.

When reacting to tragedy:

¹*The Contemporary English [computer file], electronic ed., Logos Library System, (Nashville: Thomas Nelson) 1997, c1995 by the American Bible Society.*

I. Take time to MOURN (1:4)

- A. It is okay to cry.
- B. We should not deny our true feelings of grief.
- C. It is not a sign of strength to deny our grief.
- D. A person's mental, emotional, and physical health demands that we take time to mourn when necessary.

II. Take time to MEDITATE (1:4b--11)

- A. Meditation involves Confession
- B. Meditation involves Petition
- C. Meditation involves Intercession
- D. Meditation involves Introspection

III. THEN MOVE TO ACTION (1:11B--2:8)

- A. Avoid getting "stuck" in grief process.
- B. Constructively DO what you can about the situation, as God leads, in His timing.
- C. Action is grief's best therapy.
(example: If cancer is your tragedy, begin or get active in helping other cancer patients)
- D. God will provide the resources for recuperation from tragedy.

Conclusion:

To face tragedy constructively, Nehemiah offers a very healthy example. God blesses every effort to react constructively to the tragedies of life. Have you taken time to mourn, meditate, and then move to action?

HOW TO OVERCOME DIFFICULTY

(BROWN FONT DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN)

(BLUE FONT DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE)

II. DURING DIFFICULT EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD SEEK GOD!

Psalms 34:1-4 (NKJV) “I will bless the LORD at all times; His praise shall continually be in my mouth. ²My soul shall make its boast in the LORD; The humble shall hear of it and be glad.³Oh, magnify the LORD with me, And let us exalt His name together.⁴I sought the LORD, and He heard me, And delivered me from all my fears.”

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds of experiences and challenges. The **life experience which we have discussed and the proper response is: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- In happy experiences we should praise God...

Today we are going to talk about seeking God in the difficult experiences of life.

In this passage of Scripture the Psalmist makes his audience aware of several things with regard to the experiences of life:

- He decides to praise God, no matter what was transpiring in his life...
- He made up his mind that any boasting must be with regard to the greatness of God...
- Those who have been humbled by the experiences of life will hear of his decision to seek God in difficult times, and it will be an encouragement to them...
- He welcomes all his hearers, readers, and followers to join him in worship of the God who has power over the experiences of life...

- He makes his audience aware of the need to seek God in difficult times and to believe he hears their prayers, which will result in God delivering them from all their trouble...

Difficulty is a common denominator for all human beings. It makes little difference whether you are from: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- A prominent or obscure family...
- An educated or uneducated experience...
- An impoverished or affluent background....
- A developed nation or a third world country...

Difficulty will flow in and out of your life no matter where you come from or who you are related to! Peter Marshall said, *"When we long for a life without difficulty, we need to be reminded that an oak tree grows strong in adverse winds and that diamonds are formed under pressure."*

Jesus said, John 16:31 (NKJV) ***"These things I have spoken to you, that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world."***

The fact is, as long as we live in this world full of trouble, we will face our fair share of difficult situations. How we deal with difficulty will go a long ways toward defining who we are and how we will be remembered.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

One of the things I want to make abundantly clear; for the Christian, all difficulty can be traced to one of two sources:

- We have sinned by stepping outside the protection of Gods care...
(God placed a hedge around Job and God has a hedge of protection around all Christians) (The only way the devil could attack Job was to either get him out from behind Gods hedge of protection or secure the consent of the Lord to attack Job and his family) (Nothing has changed) James 1 :14-15 (KJV) ***"Every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed."*** ¹⁵*Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death."*
- The difficulty has been allowed by the Lord... (God measured the faith of Job and measured the test, declaring Job strong enough to endure the testing) Job 1:6-12 (NKJV) ***"Now there was a day when***

the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. ⁷And the LORD said to Satan, "From where do you come?" So Satan answered the LORD and said, "From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it." ⁸Then the LORD said to Satan, "Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil?" ⁹So Satan answered the LORD and said, "Does Job fear God for nothing? ¹⁰"Have You not made a hedge around him, around his household, and around all that he has on every side? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land. ¹¹"But now, stretch out Your hand and touch all that he has, and he will surely curse You to Your face!" ¹²And the LORD said to Satan, "Behold, all that he has is in your power; only do not lay a hand on his person." So Satan went out from the presence of the LORD."

The first kind of difficulty is self-inflicted and is eternally destructive. When we step outside the protection of God's grace, we open up ourselves to difficulty which will never turn out for good. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** This is self-inflicted, self-destructive behavior. 1 Timothy 6:7-10 (NKJV) "*We brought nothing into this world, and it is certain we can carry nothing out. ⁸And having food and clothing, with these we shall be content. ⁹But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and harmful lusts which drown men in destruction and perdition. ¹⁰For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows."*

The second kind of difficulty has passed through the clearing house of God! Our Heavenly Father has pre-measured the difficulty before it was initiated in our lives and He has deemed our faith sufficient for the test! When this kind of difficulty ends several things will have transpired: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The work of Satan will have been defeated...
- The Believer will have been strengthened...
- God will have received the glory...

Phyllis Buttome said, *“There are two ways to meet difficulty; you alter the difficulty; or you alter yourself to meet the difficulty.”* When a believer senses the onslaught of difficult situations and times, the first thing one should do is to seek the Lord! **Why should one seek God when difficulty arises? (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To determine whether sin is present...
- To determine whether one is in the will of God...
- To determine how the Lord would want one to react...

Think of all the people who followed this matrix to its successful conclusion: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Moses at the Red Sea...
- David when fleeing from Saul...
- Daniel in the Lion’s Den...
- Paul and Silas in prison... (At midnight they prayed and sang praises to God – God responded with an earthquake – The Philippian Jailer and his entire family were converted)
- John the Revelator on the Island of Patmos...

John Wesley, one of the great preachers of the past, knew what it meant to endure trials. Listen to these excerpts from his diary:

- Sunday, A.M., May 5 Preached in St. Anne’s... Was asked not to come back anymore.
- Sunday, P.M., May 5 Preached in St. John’s... Deacons said, *“Get out and stay out.”*
- Sunday, A.M., May 12 Preached in St. Jude’s... Can’t go back there, either.
- Sunday, A.M., May 19 Preached in St. Somebody Else’s... Deacons called special meeting and said I couldn’t return.
- Sunday, P.M., May 19 Preached on street... Kicked off street.
- Sunday, A.M., May 26 Preached in meadow... Chased out of meadow, as bull was turned loose during service.
- Sunday, A.M., June 2 Preached out at the edge of town... Kicked off the highway.
- Sunday, P.M., June 2 [This] Afternoon [I] preached in a pasture... Ten thousand people came out to hear me.

What does this say to us? Keep on preaching, keep on believing, keep on trusting, keep on working, keep on fighting, and victory will come our way! I don't know about you, but that encourages me!

If seeking the Lord when confronted with difficult experiences worked for a who's who like this, I think it will work for us!

I want to finish this subject with one Scripture which I think will be an encouragement to all who are grappling with difficulty. Psalms 37:23-25 (NLT) *"The steps of the godly are directed by the LORD. He delights in every detail of their lives."*²⁴*Though they stumble, they will not fall, for the LORD holds them by the hand."*²⁵*Once I was young, and now I am old. Yet I have never seen the godly forsaken, nor seen their children begging for bread."*

HOW TO OVERCOME PAIN

IV. IN PAINFUL EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD TRUST GOD!

Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding;⁶ *In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.*”

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds of experiences and challenges. The [life experiences we have discussed](#) and the proper responses are: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- In happy experiences we should praise God...
- In difficult experiences we should seek God...
- In quiet experiences we should worship God...

Today we are going to talk about trusting God in the painful experiences of life.

Pain is an emotion which if not properly dealt with can dull the senses and leave one critical or worse yet, bitter. None of us can afford to have this happen to us so it is imperative that we learn to properly respond to pain. The proper response to pain is to trust God. This is probably the most difficult thing to do of any response we could have, but we can be assured it is the most beneficial response. [Trusting God in painful experiences is the right thing to do for:](#) **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Ourselves...
- Our family...
- Our church...

- Our acquaintances...
- Our walk with God...

Pain can be brought into our lives from many sources:

- Our family can create pain...
- We can create pain for ourselves...
- Friends and acquaintances can create pain...
- Accidents and health incidents can create pain...
- Unforeseen financial difficulties can create pain...

More times than not, painful experiences come upon us quite suddenly and unexpectedly.

Because painful experiences seem to come upon us without prior notice they present challenges which are extremely difficult to handle. The Word of God addresses the issue of unexpected painful experiences. Proverbs 3:25-26 (KJV) ***“Do not be afraid of sudden terror, Nor of trouble from the wicked when it comes; ²⁶ For the LORD will be your confidence, And will keep your foot from being caught.”***

There are two ways for the child of God to respond in times of unexpected painful experiences: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Panic...** This response helps no one and even serves to complicate the matter. 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV) ***“God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.”*** (My Mom & Dad’s response when my sister was bitten by a poisonous snake)
- **Trust...** It is for certain the situation will not be made better through panic, so the proper response is to trust the Lord. Trust is the demonstration of faith! (My Dad’s response when my sister was bitten by a poisonous snake)

The fact is that all of us will deal with a certain amount of pain in our lives, how we deal with it will determine our future and will also establish how others see us.

Trusting God is easier to talk about than to do. **(PLAY GEICO COMMERCIAL HERE)**

In her book “Gateway to Joy, Elisabeth Elliot said, *“God is God. Because He is God, He is worthy of my trust and obedience. I will find rest nowhere but in His holy will; a will that is unspeakably beyond my largest notions of what He is up to.”* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

The reason it is so difficult for us to trust God is because human help is right at our fingertips! Think of this: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- If we are having family problems we can call a counselor...
- If we are having financial problems we can call a banker...
- If we are having emotional problems we can call a psychiatrist or psychologist...
- If we are having problems finding a job we can call a head hunter...

I am not personally opposed to human help and resources but I think that because of its availability and accessibility we often miss out on the adventure of trusting God! Painful experiences usually place us in a position of making a decision of trusting man or trusting God! I think I would rather take my chances on God! Vernon Paterson said, *“There are always uncertainties ahead, but there is always one certainty--God's will is good.”* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

HOW TO GET DOUBLE FOR YOUR TROUBLE

In attempting to discover how to properly respond to painful experiences I do not think we would find a Bible character with more expertise on the subject than a man named Job. Job had more than a little pain to deal with in his life. Consider this about Job: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Job loved, followed, and respected God... Job 1:1 (NKJV) ***“There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was blameless and upright, and one who feared God...”***
- Job did nothing to initiate the pain in his life; his pain was created in a conversation between God and the devil... Job 1:6-12 (NKJV) ***“Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. (The devil is not repelled by the presence of God, he is actually attracted to it) ⁷And the LORD said to Satan, “From where do you come?” So Satan answered the LORD and said, “From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it.” ⁸Then the LORD said to Satan, “Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil?” (Wow, talk about high recommendations) ⁹So Satan answered the LORD and said, “Does Job fear God for nothing? ¹⁰“Have You not made a hedge around him, around his household, and around all that he has on every side? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land. (The accusation was that Job was serving God for what he could get – I***

wonder if we could pass the smell test on this?) ¹¹**“But now, stretch out Your hand and touch all that he has, and he will surely curse You to Your face!”** ¹²**And the LORD said to Satan, “Behold, all that he has is in your power; only do not lay a hand on his person.” So Satan went out from the presence of the LORD.**” The pain in Job’s life was initiated by God bragging about him to the devil!

- **Job stood against evil and injustice...** Job 1:1 (NKJV) ***“There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was blameless and upright, and one who feared God and shunned evil.”***
- **Job had a sub-par support group which dealt him even more grief...** His friends and his wife spent seven days and nights attempting to unearth a reason for his pain. His wife, who should have been his strongest supporter makes a startling statement in Job 2:9 (NKJV) ***“Then his wife said to him, “Do you still hold fast to your integrity? Curse God and die!”***
- **Job knew God would develop the greater good in his life...** Listen to how Job answers the ridiculous remarks of his own wife, Job 2:10 (NKJV) ***“You speak as one of the foolish women speaks. Shall we indeed accept good from God, and shall we not accept adversity?” In all this Job did not sin with his lips.***
- **Job trusted God...** Job 13:15-16 (NKJV) ***“ Though He slay me, yet will I trust Him. Even so, I will defend my own ways before Him.*** ¹⁶***He also shall be my salvation...***” Seven times the book of Job employs the word trust. Job was a trusting man; he trusted God and God alone! God trusted Job! Do we trust God? Can God trust us?
- **Job was a patient man...** He patiently endured the pain and received the reward for all the suffering! Job 42:10 (NKJV) ***“And the LORD turned the captivity of Job, when he prayed for his friends: also the LORD gave Job twice as much as he had before.”*** **JOB’S**

WEALTH BEFORE THE TRIAL: 7,000 sheep @ \$245.00 each - \$1,715,000.00; 3,000 camels.@ \$3,500.00 each -\$10,500,000.00; 1,000 oxen @ \$600.00 each - \$600,000.00; 500 Donkeys @\$600.00 each - \$300,000.00; **TOTAL ESTIMATED VALUE:** \$13,115,000.00 - **JOB’S WEALTH AFTER THE TRIAL:** 14,000

sheep @ \$245.00 each -\$3,430,000.00; 6,000 camels @ \$3,500.00 each -\$21,000,000.00; 2,000 oxen @ \$600.00 each -\$1,200,000.00; 1,000 Donkeys @ \$600.00 each - \$600,000.00; **TOTAL ESTIMATED VALUE AFTER THE TRIAL: \$26,230,000.00** Job 42:16 (NKJV) *"After this lived Job an hundred and forty years, and saw his sons, and his sons' sons, even four generations."* Job was 70 years old when his trial began, and he lived to be 210 years old! God gave him twice as much life following his head-on collision with the devil, than he had before his problems! Think about that, God doubled his life span! Trusting God pay's off in a big way!

Life will no doubt deal us some pain and others will lend a helping hand. What life and others do not do we will create for ourselves. Though there will be pain throughout our lives the real question is, **can we trust God in the painful times?** **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)** If we cannot position ourselves to trust God in the painful experiences of life we will never become what our Heavenly Father planned for us to be. If we can learn to trust God even though there are painful experiences, we can become everything He has purposed for our lives! Trust God in the painful experiences of life!

HOW TO GET DOUBLE FOR YOUR TROUBLE

Blue denotes PPT slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: Genesis 41:50-52 (NKJV) “And to Joseph were born two sons before the years of famine came, whom Asenath, the daughter of Poti-Pherah priest of On, bore to him. 51 Joseph called the name of the firstborn Manasseh: “For God has made me forget all my toil and all my father’s house.” 52 And the name of the second he called Ephraim: “For God has caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”

Joseph was one of the twelve sons of Jacob.

At the age of seventeen, Joseph was employed as a shepherd in his family’s ranching business.

Without ever knowing names in this story, one could pretty well predict a head-on collision in the relationship department within this family:

- Jacob favored Rachel over Leah...
- Joseph was born to Jacob and Rachel late in life...
- Jacob favored Joseph above his other sons...

Joseph seemed to be on a fast track to success. He could convince his father of anything. His father rolled out the red carpet any time Joseph came around. It was obvious to the other brothers that Jacob was going to find a way to resource Joseph above anyone or anything else.

The actions of Jacob created an impasse in his family. More importantly, it created issues between his sons that were irreconcilable.

While Joseph seemed to be in the passing lane of life, he was about to hit a traffic jam. This traffic jam was going to set up a detour through four great tests that would determine who Joseph could become.

The four great tests of Joseph's life were:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The test of Vision...
- The test of Character...
- The test of Patience...

- The test of Success...

THE TEST OF VISION

Because of the situation in his home, his brothers hated Joseph. [John 15:18-20](#)

[\(NKJV\)](#) “If the world hates you, you know that it hated Me before it hated you. 19 If you were of the world, the world would love its own. Yet because you are not of the world, but I chose you out of the world, therefore the world hates you. 20 Remember the word that I said to you, ‘A servant is not greater than his master.’ If they persecuted Me, they will also persecute you. If they kept My word, they will keep yours also.”

If we are able to live a life that really counts, we will attract some haters along the way.

Shake the haters off! (Song: You Gotta Keep Walking) (Keep paddling your canoe)

As if the dysfunction in this family was not bad enough, Jacob gave Joseph a coat of many colors! The gifting of this coat of many colors was filled with meaning:

- It indicated special favor...
- It denoted covenant relationship...
- It signaled family leadership...

To add insult to injury, Joseph started to dream dreams of exaltation. (Binding sheaves in the field and the sheaves of his father, mother and brothers bowing down to

his sheave; Dream of the sun, moon and eleven stars bowing down to him) When we start telling our dream, people are going to react:

- Some will be excited...
- Some will be supportive...
- Some will be helpful...
- Some will be skeptical...
- Some will exert resistance...
- Some will be absolutely hateful...

When Joseph told his dream, no one was excited, supportive, or helpful!

Jacob, who thought Joseph was “*Da Man*,” was very skeptical.

His brothers, who already had issues with him, did not react very well to the unveiling of Joseph’s dreams. [Genesis 37:3-5 \(NKJV\)](#)

“Now Israel loved Joseph more than all his children, because he was the son of his old age. Also he made him a tunic of many colors. 4 But when his brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers, they hated him and could not speak peaceably to him. 5 Now Joseph had a dream, and he told it to his brothers; and they hated him even more.”

It is very disappointing, even downright deflating, when we roll our vision out and the very people we thought would be excited

about it, resist it and even hate us because of it.

No one accomplishes a vision without some pockets of resistance and a few haters. Mark my word...every God sized vision will be tested.

Just because we hit some resistance does not mean we have the wrong vision! Just because we acquire some haters along the way is no indication that we should:

- Give up...
- Throw in the towel...
- Raise the flag of surrender...
- Let the fat lady start singing...

Joseph's brothers conspired to kill him, but Reuben said ***“Let's put him in a pit, and leave him there.”*** Reuben planned to return later and deliver Joseph unto his father. Reuben was hoping that with a little time things would calm down.

The brothers of Joseph failed to consider that the tallest tree was once a sapling. We must be careful how we treat people as we

ascend the ladder of success; we may need their assistance as we come back down.

Every God sized vision is planned through the pit. No dream will be accomplished until it has been thoroughly tested. This means we will more than likely experience times when we look at where the vision has taken us and say, *“This is the pits!”*

Just because our vision has driven us to the pits, is no excuse for us to give up on the vision! If we stay with the vision, the very dream we rode into the pit will be the one that will drive us out of the pit! 2

Corinthians 1:8-10 (NKJV) *“For we do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, of our trouble which came to us in Asia: that we were burdened beyond measure, above strength, so that we despaired even of life. 9 Yes, we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves but in God who raises the dead, 10 who delivered us from so great a death,*

and does deliver us; in whom we trust that He will still deliver us, “

Joseph’s brothers took his coat away from him, then dipped it in animal blood and gave it to Jacob telling him, “***Some wild animal probably killed Joseph.***” Reuben is the only brother who showed any compassion toward Joseph. Reuben intended to return to the pit and retrieve Joseph but it was not to be so.

When our vision is being tested, there will be well-intentioned people who can see it and believe it, but because of the peer pressure, cannot muster the courage to break with the crowd and embrace it. How disappointing! (Chickens)

The rest of the brothers placed Joseph in the pit long enough to find some slave traders who were willing to buy him. When our vision is being tested, there will be people we trust in our circle of influence, who will sell us down the river. [Psalm 55:12-14](#)

(CEV) “My enemies are not the ones who sneer and make fun. I could put up with that or even hide from them. 13 But it was my closest friend, the one I trusted

most. 14 We enjoyed being together, and we went with others to your house, our God.
“

Joseph's vision was being tested to the limit and ours will be as well. There is no such thing as an untested vision. *“If you limit your choices only to what seems possible or reasonable, you disconnect yourself from what you truly want, and all that is left is a compromise.” - Robert Fritz* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

We may experience times when we have been sold down the river, but if it is a God vision, our canoe can withstand the current.

Joseph was brought out of the pit and sold to the Ishmaelite slave traders for 20 pieces of silver. When our vision is being tested, the light at the end of the tunnel is often an oncoming train.

If we can ride the test until it becomes a testimony, the vision God has given us will not only survive, it will thrive! **Jeremiah**

29:11 (NKJV) “For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the Lord, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”

If we have a vision, it will be tested. What kind of price are we willing to pay to follow God to reveal our destiny?

To get double for our trouble, we must be able to pass the vision test. To pass the vision test we must believe:

- The vision is more important than our comfort...
- The vision is more important than public opinion...
- The vision is more important than the opposition...

How important is the vision? Can we pass the vision test? If we want double for our trouble, the vision will need to be tested. Are we up to the test? What will we do? Will we rise above the fray or embrace an inferior idea?

SONG: “I’m Still Standing”

THE TEST OF CHARACTER

Genesis 39:1-6 (KJV) “And Joseph was brought down to Egypt; and Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, captain of the guard, an Egyptian, bought him of the hands of the Ishmaelites, which had brought him down thither. 2 And the Lord was with Joseph, and he was a prosperous man; and he was in the house of his master the Egyptian. 3 And his master saw that the Lord was with him, and that the Lord made all that he did to prosper in his hand. 4 And Joseph found grace in his sight, and he served him: and he made him overseer over his house, and all that he had he put into his hand. 5 And it came to pass from the time that he had made him overseer in his house, and over all that he had, that the Lord blessed the Egyptian's house for Joseph's sake; and the blessing of the Lord was upon all that he had in the house, and in the field. 6 And he left all that he had in Joseph's hand; and he knew not ought he had, save the bread which he did eat. And Joseph was a goodly person, and well favoured.”

The Ishmaelite slave traders sold Joseph to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh. Potiphar was a very successful Egyptian businessman, and early on he noticed that the Lord was with Joseph. As Joseph

worked for Potiphar, everything he touched seemed to turn to gold.

In time, Potiphar turned everything he had over to Joseph, and consequently Joseph became the chief operating officer of his house and business enterprises. God prospered Joseph as Potiphar's COO, and Potiphar realized some very hefty profits. The character test began when Potiphar's wife began to flirt with Joseph. This flirtation turned to proposition as Joseph steadfastly resisted her advances. I do not believe Mrs. Potiphar was an ugly woman. Temptation is always attractive. ***“There is pleasure in sin for a season.”***

In the house of Potiphar, Joseph found himself embroiled in a fight for his character. This fight was not about mere resistance; it was about whether Joseph would ever realize his vision.

Joseph refused to give in because he was determined to get double for his trouble!

Joseph was:

1) Young and lonely... 1 Timothy 4:12

(NKJV) “Let no one despise your youth, but be an example to the believers in word, in conduct, in love, in spirit, in faith, in purity.”

2) Suffering from rejection... Psalm 27:10

(NKJV) “*When my father and my mother forsake me, then the Lord will take care of me.*”

3) Away from home... No one would know, would they? Job 28:24 (AMP) “For He looks to the

ends of the earth and sees everything under the heavens.” Job 23:10

(NKJV) “He knows the way that I take; when He has tested me, I shall come forth as gold.”

4) Especially vulnerable at all levels...

Isaiah 43:1-2 (NKJV) “But now, thus says the Lord, who created you, O Jacob, and He who formed you, O Israel: “Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by your name;

You are Mine. 2 When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and through the rivers, they shall not overflow you. When you walk through the fire, you shall not be burned, nor shall the flame scorch you.”

Listen to the guiding principle of Joseph’s battle for his own character and his effort to get double for his trouble. Genesis 39:7-9

(NKJV) “*I*t came to pass after these things that his master’s wife cast longing eyes on Joseph, and she said, “Lie with me.” 8 But he refused and said to his master’s wife, “Look, my master does not know what is with me in the house, and he has committed all that he has to my hand. 9 There is no one greater in this house than I, nor has he kept back anything from me but you, because you are his wife. How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?”

Joseph was more concerned about sinning against God than disappointing his parents or defaming his religion. *“There is no such thing as a minor lapse of integrity.”* – Tom Peters

“A person who is fundamentally honest doesn't need a code of ethics. The Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount are all the ethical code anybody needs.” – Harry S. Truman

If we can be faithful despite the test of our character, we move one step closer to getting double for our trouble.

The battle for Joseph's integrity reached such a crescendo that one day, while fulfilling his assignments, Potiphar's wife made one last effort to get Joseph to fail the integrity test. When her advances were denied, she accused this man of character, of attempted rape.

To pass the character test we must:

- Be honest with God and man...

- Refuse to bow at the altar of compromise...
- Stay the course when others take ethical detours...

If one passes the character test, he/she is one step closer to getting double for their trouble.

Mark Twain said, *“You cannot depend on your eyes when your imagination is out of focus.”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERMON)**

THE TEST OF SUCCESS

Genesis 41:39-44 (CEV) “The king told Joseph, “God is the one who has shown you these things. No one else is as wise as you are or knows as much as you do. 40 I’m putting you in charge of my palace, and everybody will have to obey you. No one will be over you except me. 41 You are now governor of all Egypt!” 42 Then the king took off his royal ring and put it on Joseph’s finger. He gave him fine clothes to wear and placed a gold chain around his neck. 43 He also let him ride in the chariot next to his own, and people shouted, “Make way for Joseph!” So Joseph was governor of Egypt. 44 The king told Joseph, “Although I’m king, no one in Egypt is to do anything without your permission.”

Joseph was about to discover that the test of success would be his greatest test to date.

How we handle success reveals who we really are. *“Nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's*

character, give him power.” — Abraham Lincoln

Most people think when success comes everything will be smooth sailing. The truth is the test of success reveals things about us that neither others, nor we, knew previously. Once Joseph settled into his new responsibilities, he married and God gave him two sons. *Genesis 41:50-52 (MSG)*

“Joseph had two sons born to him before the years of famine came. Asenath, daughter of Potiphera the priest of On, was their mother. Joseph named the firstborn Manasseh (Forget), saying, “God made me forget all my hardships and my parental home.” He named his second son Ephraim (Double Prosperity), saying, “God has prospered me in the land of my sorrow.”

In Bible days parents rarely named their children based on what they thought sounded good, they named them for something of great significance in their lives. *Genesis 41:51 (MSG) “Joseph named the firstborn Manasseh (Forget), saying, “God made me forget all my hardships and my parental home.”* What does Manasseh mean? It means forgetfulness.

By naming his son Manasseh (Forgetfulness), Joseph is not saying that he had forgotten about what his brothers had put him through. He had certainly not lost the memory of his father, mother, or brothers. When his brothers came to buy corn in Egypt, they did not recognize Joseph, but he immediately recognized them.

By naming his son Manasseh, he was saying God had taken the pain out of a past experience for him. If we intend to pass the success test and get double for our trouble, we must release the pain of the past.

When we fail to release those who have hurt us, we are constantly tethered to the past. (Illustrate this)

Being tethered to the past causes us to spend more time peering into what happened at a former intersection of our life rather than following the GPS (Gods Plan directed by the Spirit) into our future. *"If you limit your*

choices only to what seems possible or reasonable, you disconnect yourself from what you truly want, and all that is left is a compromise."

— Robert Fritz

If anyone had reason to be bitter and have a critical attitude, certainly Joseph did. What's our excuse? If we are bitter or critical we need to ask ourselves:

- Have we been kidnapped or held against our will?
- Did our siblings put us in a pit or sell us into slavery?
- Have we spent years in prison as a result of false charges?
- Have we been separated from our families against our will for thirteen years?

When his first son was born, Joseph named him Manasseh, ***"The Lord hath made me to forget"***

The proof is unmistakable that Joseph had allowed God to take the pain out of a past experience and allowed forgiveness to replace the hurt:

- He did not retaliate against the butler...
- He did not even the score with Mrs. Potiphar...
- He did not take revenge against his brothers...
- He blessed his father's house when he could have exterminated them...

Un-forgiveness locks the victim in a self-imposed prison. The only means of escape is for the offended to forgive the offender.

Please allow me to ask some questions about what we plan to do when we achieve the success we have been working toward:

- Are we going to flaunt the success before our naysayers?
- Are we going to retaliate against those who have opposed us?

- Are we going to exact revenge on those who have caused us pain?
- Are we going to undo the success of those who stepped on our fingers while they were climbing the ladder of success?
- Are we going to develop a bad attitude toward those who have treated us with a lack of dignity and respect along the way?

The test of success is not as easy as it seems. Joseph named his first son Manasseh so that every time he referred to his son by name, it was a constant reminder that he could not afford to let un-forgiveness and bitterness cloud the vision God had called him to. Joseph intended to get double for his trouble, and he knew that he had to forgive to get it!

If we allow the pain of past experiences to become the guiding principle in our lives,

we will fail the success test and become another statistic on the trash heap of human wreckage. If we refuse to forgive, we will never know the joy of receiving double for our trouble.

If Joseph could endure all this and forget the past, surely you and I can forget the past and serve God victoriously. [Philippians 3:13-14](#)

[\(NKJV\)](#) “Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, 14 I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”

I want us to look at two very important aspects of the test of success:

- What should we forget? We should forget past hurts – past failures – past successes.
- How do I forget? Forgive – give up on the need to get even – turn retribution over to God – move on with our lives – expend our energy and resources moving toward the vision, rather than trying to make sure the naysayers have been dealt

with. **Romans 12:19 (KJV)** Dearly beloved, avenge not yourselves, but rather give place unto wrath: for it is written, "Vengeance is mine; I will repay," saith the Lord.

If we want double for our trouble, we should pay close attention to the actions of Joseph when his brothers came to Egypt to purchase corn:

- He sold them corn and put their money back in their sacks.
- He kept Simeon so that they would bring Benjamin (a brother he had never met) back with them. When they returned, he made a feast for them.
- He sold them corn and supplies and once again put their money back in their sacks.
- He placed his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and let them go.
- After they left, he sent his servants to retrieve them.

- His servants searched their belongings and of course found Joseph's silver cup in Benjamin's sack.

His brothers pleaded for mercy and Joseph revealed his true identity. [Genesis 45:7-8](#)

[\(KJV\)](#) “And God sent me before you to preserve you a posterity in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance. 8 So now it was not you that sent me hither, but God: and he hath made me a father to Pharaoh, and lord of all his house, and a ruler throughout all the land of Egypt.”

The real story here is the reason for Joseph's ascent to a position of influence; he forgave his brothers before they asked for forgiveness.

How could he do such a thing? Because ***“The Lord hath made me to forget.”***

Please note: From the time Joseph was named Prime Minister until his brothers arrived in Egypt to buy corn, was approximately nine years.

We are made aware that Joseph had two sons, the name of his second son was Ephraim. Ephraim means, ***“Double fruit.”***

Genesis 41:52 (KJV) “And the name of the second called he Ephraim: For God hath caused me to be fruitful in the land of my affliction.”

There are 2 things here for us to note:

- God caused Joseph to be fruitful. We must recognize that all success comes from God.
- God caused Joseph to be fruitful in the land of his affliction. Anyone can succeed when everything is going right! God is looking for people who have the tenacity to succeed in the good times as well as the bad times.

God is looking for some folks that can blossom despite the circumstances and surroundings and maintain their integrity throughout the onslaught of success.

How did God bless him?

- Financially... He became the Prime Minister and received the salary that went with such a position!

- Family... A wife and two sons! It doesn't get any better than that! Every time Joseph called one of his sons by name, he was reminding himself of the miracles of God!
- Position... Joseph's authority was second only to Pharaoh! Not too bad for an illegal immigrant!

CONCLUSION:

Though Joseph experienced the zenith of his success in Egypt, it was never home to Joseph. According to the Scripture, we are also “*pilgrims and strangers*” here. We are living in the land of affliction, so to speak. Joseph lived in the land of affliction, but he walked uprightly before God. Because he walked uprightly before God, God blessed him.

No matter how good or difficult the journey becomes, we must keep in mind that this world is not our end game. Joseph had a good run in Egypt, but listen to what he says

just before his death. [Genesis 50:24-25](#)

[\(KJV\)](#) And Joseph said unto his brethren, “I die: and God will surely visit you, and bring you out of this land unto the land which he sware to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.” 25 And Joseph took an oath of the children of Israel, saying, “God will surely visit you, and ye shall carry up my bones from hence.”